

The AI Landscape

Understanding Today's AI Tools

The Roadmap

- What is AI and how to interact with it
- Conversational AI: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity
- Image and Video: DALL-E, Midjourney, NanoBanana, Sora
- Everyday tasks: Grammarly, Notion, Otter, Copilot/Duet
- Choosing the right tool for your needs
- Getting started: Costs and Subscription Options

PART 1: UNDERSTANDING AI ASSISTANTS

What is an AI Assistant?

- Large Language Model (LLM) that uses natural language
- A mix between a personal assistant and Google
- Can help with:
 - Writing and editing
 - Research and learning
 - Problem-solving and brainstorming
 - Creative projects

How AI Assistants Work

- You type or speak a question or request
- The AI processes your input and generates a response
- You can have back-and-forth conversations
- The AI remembers context within a conversation
- Think of it as texting with a very smart friend

Demo

- Interacting with ChatGPT/Claude

THE MAJOR TEXT AI PLATFORMS

ChatGPT by OpenAI

Strengths:

- Most popular and widely used
- GPTs: Custom versions for specific tasks
- Can browse the web (Plus version)
- DALL-E integration for images
- Voice conversations on mobile

Best for: General purpose, creative writing, learning

ChatGPT Resources

Unique Features:

- **Custom GPTs:** Pre-configured assistants
 - Academic Writer
 - Language Teacher
 - Recipe Creator
 - Fitness Coach
- **GPT Store:** Thousands of specialized GPTs
- **Memory:** Remembers preferences across chats

Claude by Anthropic

Strengths:

- Excellent at analysis and reasoning
- Artifacts: Interactive previews of work
- Projects: Organize related conversations
- Can process long documents (books, reports)
- Strong writing capabilities

Best for: Professional writing, document analysis, complex reasoning

Claude Resources

Unique Features:

- **Artifacts:** Live preview of documents, code, diagrams
- **Projects:** Keep related work together
- **Claude Code:** Desktop app for coding (advanced)
- **Document Upload:** PDFs, Word docs, spreadsheets
- **Style Customization:** Set writing preferences

Gemini by Google

Strengths:

- Deep integration with Google services
- Access to Gmail, Drive, Calendar
- YouTube video summaries
- Google Maps and Flights integration
- Real-time information from search

Best for: Google users, travel planning, research with current info

Gemini Resources

Unique Features:

- **Extensions:** Connect to your Google apps
- **Workspace Integration:** Use in Docs, Sheets
- **Bard (now Gemini):** Web search built-in
- **Multi-modal:** Understands images and text together
- **Gemini Advanced:** More powerful reasoning

Perplexity

Strengths:

- AI-powered search engine
- Always provides sources and citations
- Real-time web information
- Follow-up questions for deeper research
- Academic and news search modes

Best for: Research, fact-checking, current events, academic work

DEMO: Comparing AI Assistants

“Help me plan a 3-day trip to Paris with a \$1000 budget, including must-see attractions and local food recommendations”

What to observe:

- Response styles and formatting
- Level of detail
- Sources and citations (Perplexity)
- Interactive features (Claude Artifacts)

PART 3: IMAGE AND VIDEO AI

AI Image Generation

How it works:

- Describe what you want in words (called a “prompt”)
- AI creates original images based on your description
- You can refine and iterate

Common uses:

- Presentations and documents
- Social media content
- Creative projects
- Concept visualization

DALL-E 3 - Image Generation

What it does:

- Creates images from text descriptions
- Built into ChatGPT Plus (\$20/month)
- Understands context from your conversation

Strengths:

- Very easy to use - just describe what you want
- Can iterate: "make it more colorful"
- Good at following complex instructions

Best for: Presentations, concepts, illustrations

Midjourney - Professional Art

What it does:

- Creates high-quality artistic images
- Known for stunning, creative results

Strengths:

- Best artistic quality available
- Great for portraits and landscapes
- Strong community for learning

Cost: \$10-60/month depending on usage

Best for: Professional creative work, art projects

NanoBanana - Quick and Fun

What it does:

- Instant image generation
- Simple, fun interface

Strengths:

- Completely free
- Perfect for beginners
- Fast results for quick ideas
- Great for casual use

Best for: Quick experiments, learning prompting, fun projects

Sora - Video from Text

What it does:

- Creates realistic videos from text descriptions
- Up to 60 seconds of video
- By OpenAI

Current status:

- Limited release (not fully public yet)
- Very good quality
- Promising, but still on development

Alternatives now: Runway, Pika, Stable Video

Suno - Audio

- **What it does:**
- Creates original music from text prompts
- Generates songs with vocals and instruments
- Multiple genres and styles available
- **Strengths:**
- Full songs with lyrics
- Easy to use interface
- Free tier available

PART 4: SPECIALIZED AI TOOLS

Grammarly

What it does:

- Checks grammar, spelling, and punctuation
- Suggests tone and clarity improvements
- Works in browser, desktop, and mobile

Strengths:

- Real-time corrections as you type
- Explains why changes are suggested
- Adapts to formal/informal writing styles

Cost: Free version available, Premium \$12/month

Best for: Emails, documents, professional writing

Notion AI - Smart Workspace

What it does:

- Built into Notion note-taking app
- Helps write, summarize, and brainstorm
- Organizes and improves existing notes

Strengths:

- Generate content from your notes: summaries, actions plans
- Generate full documents, translate and rewrite text

Cost: \$10/month add-on to Notion

Best for: Note-taking, project management, documentation

Otter.ai - Meeting Transcription

What it does:

- Records and transcribes meetings automatically
- Identifies different speakers
- Creates searchable transcripts

Strengths:

- Integrates with Zoom, Teams, Google Meet
- Share highlights and action items

Cost: Free for 300 minutes/month, Pro \$10/month

Best for: Meetings, interviews, lectures

NotebookLM - Study Companion

What it does:

- Upload your research papers, PDFs, and notes
- AI becomes an expert on your materials

Strengths:

- Creates summaries and study guides
- Generates key concepts and Q&A from your documents
- Finds connections between different sources

Cost: Free

Best for: Students, researchers, learning from documents

Microsoft Copilot & Google Duet

Microsoft Copilot:

- Built into Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook
- Drafts documents, analyzes data, creates presentations
- \$30/month for Microsoft 365 users

Google Duet:

- Similar for Google Workspace (Docs, Sheets, Slides, Gmail)
- \$30/month for Workspace users

Choose based on: Which office suite you already use

Best for: Daily office work, reports, presentations

PART 5: CHOOSING THE RIGHT TOOL

Decision Framework

Consider these factors:

- **Task type:** Writing, research, creative, analysis?
- **Budget:** Free tier or paid subscription?
- **Privacy:** Personal or sensitive information?
- **Integration:** Need to work with existing tools?
- **Learning curve:** How much time to invest?

Quick Recommendations

- **Just starting?** Try ChatGPT free version
- **Student?** NotebookLM + Perplexity (both free)
- **Professional writer?** Claude Pro
- **Google user?** Gemini integrates seamlessly
- **Creative projects?** ChatGPT Plus with DALL-E
- **Research heavy?** Perplexity Pro

Free vs Paid Tiers

Free Tiers Usually Include:

- Basic conversations
- Limited daily messages
- Standard response speed

Paid Tiers (\$20/month typical) Add:

- Advanced models
- Priority access
- Additional features (web browsing, file uploads)
- Higher message limits

PART 6: GETTING STARTED

Your First Steps

1. **Start free:** Create account at ChatGPT or Claude
2. **Experiment:** Try different types of requests
3. **Learn prompting:** Be specific and clear
4. **Iterate:** Ask follow-up questions
5. **Explore:** Try specialized tools for your needs
6. **Stay informed:** AI tools evolve rapidly

Tips for Better Results

- **Be specific:** “Write a 200-word email” vs “Write an email”
- **Provide context:** Explain the situation
- **Use examples:** Show what you’re looking for
- **Iterate:** “Make it more formal” or “Shorten this”
- **Verify:** Always fact-check important information

Privacy and Safety

Important considerations:

- Never share passwords or sensitive data
- Check your organization's AI policy
- Understand data retention policies
- Use private/incognito modes when needed
- Be aware of AI-generated content policies
- Fact-check important information

Learn how to use AI safe and efficiently

- AI tools are becoming part of everyday life
- They're assistants, not replacements
- Start small, grow your skills gradually
- Focus on tools that solve your real problems
- Stay curious and keep learning

Questions?

Resources

Getting Started:

- ChatGPT: chat.openai.com
- Claude: claude.ai
- Gemini: gemini.google.com
- Perplexity: perplexity.ai

Learn More:

- OpenAI Learning: openai.com/blog
- Anthropic Research: anthropic.com
- AI newsletters: The Rundown, AI Breakfast